

there was the huge challenge of climate action and climate finance, and both SDGs and climate finance required a reorientation of the multilateral financial institutions,” he says.

But it was also an opportunity to highlight India’s achievements in digital public infrastructure (DPI) and its stellar growth story. Kant says that Prime Minister Narendra Modi wanted the presidency to be inclusive, decisive, ambitious, and action oriented. And unlike other presidencies that were restricted to the capital or cities like Delhi and Mumbai, the PM wanted this one to be taken to all the states.

“So, we ended up doing about 220 meetings in all the states and Union Territories. He wanted it to be a people’s presidency,” Kant says, adding that this required huge logistics and students from schools and colleges had to be involved. “This was the first time that foreign policy was taken to the people of India,” he adds.

The next big challenge was arriving at a consensus as multilateralism had taken a back seat. “We struggled with it throughout the year... all ministerials had failed. But in the final round, we were able to build a consensus on all key issues—with 83 paras and 217 outcomes!” Kant says, adding that the most important of these was reaching a consensus on the Russia-Ukraine conflict paragraph—something that even the UN had failed to do. This paragraph took “about 300 hours of negotiations, about 250 bilaterals and 17 drafts”, he shares.

No wonder then that the high-powered jury that picked the winners of the *BT-PwC India’s Best CEOs* ranking this year recommended that he be given a special Impact Leader of the Year award.

KANT WHO CAN

Those who know Kant say he has great clarity of mind and is a decisive speaker with a proactive approach, who works as hard—if not harder—than his team. He is also known to be extremely generous and helpful.

“Amitabh is a brilliant guy and a wonderful human being, and we both reach out to each other when we need advice on something,” says Piyush Pandey, Chief Advisor of Ogilvy India, who has known Kant for 50 years.

The advertising veteran, who was the G20 Sherpa’s batchmate at Delhi’s St. Stephen’s College, says they did not know each other too well in college as he was a cricketer, while Kant was more academically oriented. But later, they worked together on

A FINE ACT

► Amitabh Kant was appointed as India’s G20 Sherpa in July 2022

► This was months before India’s year-long presidency of the G20 started, from December 1, 2022, to November 30, 2023

► He played a key role in taking G20 meetings across the country

► He has been an ace negotiator and managed to help bring consensus for the Delhi Declaration

► Kant is currently working on taking forward India’s agenda during Brazil’s presidency and assisting the South American country as part of the G20 troika (Indonesia is the third member of this grouping)

